Livestock Judging Teams and Results

1913

Left to Right: Jack Smith, E. Tourtellotte, C.C. Stinson, M.B. Campbell, James Connell

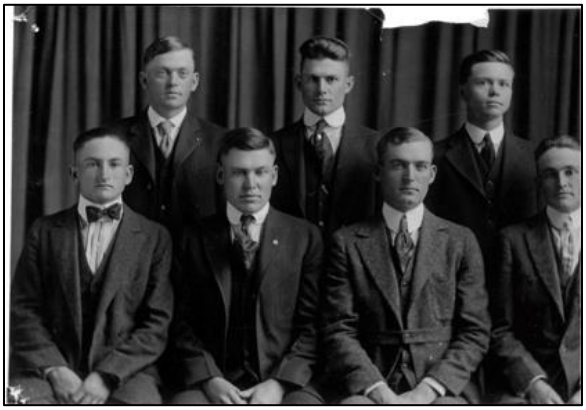
Contest Results:

2nd- Fort Worth

13th- Chicago International

1918

Left to Right: W.H. (Bill) Smith, W.L. Blizzard (Coach), A.E. Darlow, Lawrence E. Correll, L.O. Putnam, Don Orr



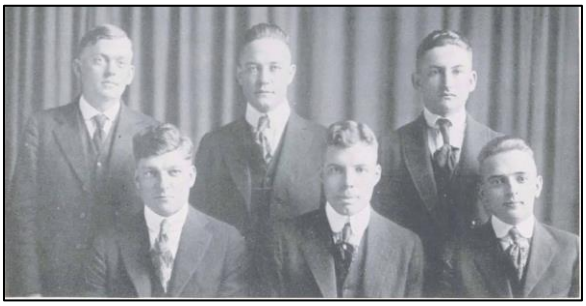
1919

Left to Right: W.L. Blizzard (Coach), Fred Ahrberg, Bonham, Harry Garlock, W.H. (Bill) Smith, Roscoe Keiffer

Contest Results:

7th- Chicago International

- Harry Garlock and Roscoe Keiffer were the 2nd and 8th high individuals, respectively.



1920

Left to Right: W.L. Blizzard (Coach), Claud L. Bunyard, Orman Nash, H.A. Graham, William B. Forrester (High Individual at International in Chicago), Chester A. Clausen

Contest Results:

1st- Oklahoma City

1st- Fort Worth

10th- Chicago International

1921

Left to Right: W.L. Blizzard (Coach), Don C. Foster, Charles Upp, Curtis Floyd, Edfred Shannon, Olin Farrington, Robert Penquite, Paul Adams. Not Pictured: Floyd Beanblossom

Contest Results:

1st- Fort Worth

3rd- Chicago International

1922

Left to Right: Whitham D. Finney, Oliver S.Wilham, C.L. Crabtree, L. Perry, Rolland C. Outhier, R.F. Cox, Dan Arnold, W.L. Blizzard (Coach)

Contest Results:

1st- Fort Worth

6th- Chicago International

1923

Front Row: W.L. Blizzard (Coach), Reeder, Reynolds, V. Godley, Young, L. Godley, Arnold, A.E. Darlow, Clark Kinhead

Contest Results:

1st - Oklahoma City

2nd - Fort Worth

7th - Chicago International

Coaches

Frank C. Burtis (1899-1912)

Frank Burtis was a faculty member in the Animal Husbandry Department at then Oklahoma Agricultural and Mechanical College. While introducing the department's first dairy classes and starting the iconic "Dairy Bar", Burtis decided to offer a livestock evaluation course in 1899. At the time, much of the livestock housed at the college farms were below breed standards and of poor quality. Burtis recognized this, and acquired literature from registered livestock associations to help teach the course and, eventually, aid in his coaching of the team. Burtis took his students to the American Royal Livestock Exposition in Kansas City for their first out-of-state competition in 1902.

Charles I. Bray (1913-1914)

Charles Bray's stint as coach was short-lived, but marked a turning point in the program's history. Bray took the team to the 1913 International Livestock Exposition in Chicago, where they finished in last. This result should not reflect poorly on Bray and his abilities; rather, team members had rarely, or never, worked with prize animals like those in Chicago, and their poor scores were indicative of this inexperience. Fortunately, this result set into motion a series of steps made by the college to give our future teams the best shot at success possible,

including enhanced breeding programs at the college's animal units, building new facilities, and hiring of qualified faculty.

Warren L. Blizzard (1915-1924)

One of those hires was Warren Blizzard on February 18, 1915. Blizzard played a crucial role in elevating Oklahoma's livestock industry when the state was still in its infancy. Upon recognizing the university's lack of quality herd bulls, he purchased 28 head of breeding stock for the experiment station. This set a foundation and precedent for the university to be a source of quality livestock across multiple livestock species. Upon becoming head of the Animal Husbandry Department in 1919, he was crucial in continuing the momentum of the university's breeding programs and enhancing student training. Under his leadership, Oklahoma A&M secured their first Union Stock Yard and Transit Company Trophy as the national champion livestock judging team at the 1925 International in Chicago. This historic moment symbolizes the start of the university's tradition of excellence in livestock judging; however, to describe his impact in just the context of our livestock judging team would be a disservice. Blizzard is regarded as a foundational figure in Oklahoma State University's heritage with his pioneering contributions to animal husbandry education. He was honored with a portrait in the Saddle and Sirloin Club's Portrait Gallery in 1939 inducted into the Hall of Great Westerners in 1958 for his lasting impact on our university and the livestock industry.

Albert E. Darlow (1925-1934)

Albert Darlow obtained his master's degree in animal husbandry from Oklahoma State in 1922, becoming one of the very first to complete their graduate program in that field. He quickly became a key faculty member in the Department of Animal Husbandry and coached the 1925 national champion livestock judging team, Oklahoma A&M's first championship. He followed with national champion teams in 1926 and 1928 which gave permanent ownership of the Union Stock Yard and Transit Co. Trophy to Oklahoma A&M, with the "bronze bull" trophy being retired after a university has won it three times. The bull is still displayed in the Animal Science building today. Aside from adding another national championship in 1930 and several high individuals at contests along the way, Darlow was instrumental in establishing Oklahoma's

sheep herd and further shifting Oklahoma's agricultural focus towards livestock production. His reputation as a stockman and livestock evaluator is matched by his administrative achievements. He served as head of the Animal Science Department, dean of agriculture, and vice president of agriculture at OSU until his retirement in 1964. Simultaneously, he became the first president of the American Society of Animal Production in 1954. His contributions to the livestock industry earned him a Saddle and Sirloin portrait in 1958 and induction into the American Angus Heritage Foundation Hall of Fame in 1983.

Carl P. Thompson (1935-1936)

Carl Thompson joined the faculty at Oklahoma A&M in 1918. With his background consisting of over a decade raising Duroc hogs, Thompson eventually became the Animal Husbandry Department's swine specialist. While only serving as the livestock judging coach for two years, he made his impact in other ways. In addition to primary responsibilities with the university's swine operation, his humor and engaging speech made him one of the most popular lecturers on campus. His speaking talent eventually led to him being named a "goodwill ambassador" for the college in 1949. This role as an administrative field representative led to countless speaking engagements until his retirement in 1958 after 40 years of service.

Bruce R. Taylor (1937-1942)

Bruce Taylor served as a professor before coaching the livestock judging team for a five year stretch until 1942. Taylor was gaining momentum with his 1941 team emerging victorious at the National Western in Denver and rounding out the season as Reserve National Champions at the International in Chicago; however, this success was not to be continued. The United States' entry into World War II led to the cancellation of major contests like the American Royal and the International from 1942 through 1945. Although this effectively ended Taylor's time coaching the livestock judging team, he remained an involved faculty member and was the faculty advisor to the Block and Bridle Club, the university's livestock-oriented student organization.

Glen Bratcher (1946-1952)

Glen Bratcher saw success as the coach of the 1948 national champion livestock judging team, but his impact reached further through his research and leadership during his time at Oklahoma State. His studies involving beef cattle contributed greatly to advancing practical knowledge of livestock management to help support the ranching and livestock communities in the state. Eventually becoming head of the Animal Husbandry Department allowed him to shape OSU's reputation in agricultural education and extension through his leadership and integrity. He holds a respected place in OSU's history as a leader in livestock judging, education, and research that made great strides in the field of animal science.

Robert Totusek (1953-1961)

Robert Totusek is one of the most treasured figures in Oklahoma State University's history. Enduring the Great Depression and Dust Bowl eras while growing up on his family's Garber, Oklahoma, farm helped foster his deep appreciation for agriculture. He was a member of Glen Bratcher's 1948 national champion team where he finished as the second-high individual at the International. After completing his bachelor's degree at Oklahoma A&M in 1949, he earned his master's and Ph.D. in animal nutrition at Purdue University. In 1952, he returned to Oklahoma A&M to join the animal science faculty and coach the livestock judging team. During his eight-year run, He coached 2 national champion teams and 3 reserve national champion teams. As a renowned livestock judge, he was instrumental in shifting beef cattle type toward larger framed, performance-based cattle with his selection of an Angus bull known as Great Northern at the 1969 International. Dr. Totusek then served as department head at the newly renamed Oklahoma State University from 1976 to 1990. During this time, he expanded curriculum in the department, reestablished the horse program, and authored or co-authored more than 200 publications, many being in the field of beef cattle range management. His leadership also initiated the construction of facilities such as the Animal Science Building, Animal Science Arena, Food and Agricultural Products Center, Beef Cattle Research Center, and the Swine Research and Education Center. After his retirement in 1990, his 38-year career was honored with induction into the Saddle and Sirloin Club in 1997,

renaming the Animal Science Arena as the Totusek Arena, starting the Dr. Robert Totusek Lecture Series in his honor, and endowing a chair at OSU in his name in 2005. Totusek passed away on June 6, 2014, but his legacy embodies a blend of visionary leadership and personal dedication that continues to inspire students, faculty, and livestock producers across the state and beyond.

Jack McCroskey (1962-1965)

In just 4 short years, Jack McCroskey was able to coach several notable individuals. Jimmy Harrel was on the 1962 livestock judging team where he finished as the second-high individual the American Royal. As a successful rancher and owner of the Bank of Western Oklahoma, Harrell was appointed to the OSU A&M Board of Regents in 2020. Also under McCroskey's leadership was Stephen Armbruster, the high individual at the 1965 International and a legendary figure in feedlot nutrition. McCroskey was held in high regard for his research and contributions in the field of beef cattle nutrition, and in 1972 he was appointed as the Faculty Council Chair where his governance and faculty leadership helped shape academic policies and advance the university's agricultural research mission. His mentorship and scholarly influence made an indelible impact on the Animal Science Department and university as a whole.

Don Pinney (1966-1971)

Aside from his six years spent coaching the livestock judging team, Don Pinney was a respected faculty member who was faculty supervisor for the Purebred Beef Cattle Center and authored or co-authored several research reports focused on beef cattle nutrition. His work includes studies on winter feeding plans and their effects on cow performance, and his influence in advancing agricultural research at OSU was notable. The Don Pinney Award was established in 1986 by the OSU Department of Animal Science. This award honors the outstanding member of each year's livestock judging team, underlining his legacy in recognizing excellence among students and his significant influence in both education and mentorship.

Bob Kropp (1972-1980)

Johnnie Robert "Bob" Kropp earned his bachelor's, master's, and Ph.D. in animal nutrition all from Oklahoma State University. In 1972, he began his career as a professor and coach of the livestock judging team. Over his nine-year run, OSU competed in 52 contests, winning 16 team titles and national championships in 1979 and 1981. He coached many successful individuals, including future coach Jarold Callahan who was the third-high individual at the International. Dr. Kropp's livestock judging expertise helped label him as a nationally recognized authority on beef cattle production. He delivered over 300 presentations across 25 states and multiple countries while also judging hundreds of livestock shows. This, alongside his consulting work for numerous registered and commercial cow-calf herds, led to involvement in industry leadership. He served on the National Board of Directors of the International Brangus Breeders of America and chaired the Breed Advisory Committee within the Texas Longhorn Breeders Association of America. His contributions to livestock judging, education, and the beef cattle industry have left a lasting imprint on the university and broader agriculture community. His legacy is continued through a scholarship fund established in his honor at OSU.

Kim Brock (1981,1991)

Kim Brock was the coach of the national champion teams at the 1981 and 1991 North American International Livestock Exposition. Aside from his successes as the livestock judging coach, his career as the Swine Herd Manager at OSU had a far-reaching impact on the Oklahoma pork industry. Over 29 years, Brock's combination of teaching and research helped benefit the industry as it stood while also helping to prepare students to become a part of the industry of the future. His ability to relate to students gained him respect and helped cultivate the interests of the many undergraduate and graduate students he mentored in swine science. His influence also reached down to youth students through his work judging livestock shows and allowing school groups to visit the OSU swine farm to deepen their industry knowledge. In 2007, Kim was honored with the Outstanding Staff Award at OSU for his unmatched educational efforts. His commitment to student mentorship, swine research, and development

of the state's pork industry earned him a spot in the Oklahoma Pork Council's Hall of Fame in 2008.

Jarold Callahan (1981-1991)

Jarold Callahan grew up on a family cattle operation near Welch, Oklahoma, and developed a passion for agriculture and livestock at an early age. Upon completing two years at Northeastern Oklahoma A&M College, he transferred to Oklahoma State University where he was a member of Bob Kropp's successful 1975 livestock judging team. After graduating in 1976 with a Bachelor's degree in Animal Science as one of the top seniors in the College of Agriculture, he earned his Master's degree in Animal Science from the University of Arkansas. After coaching a national champion team alongside Kim Brock in 1981, Callahan served as the head livestock judging coach and assistant professor of animal science at OSU until 1991. This tenure is one of the most successful in the program's storied history, being highlighted by three consecutive national champion teams in 1989, 1990, and 1991. He is described as having an exceptional ability to connect with students and develop their talents. Tandem this with his strong work ethic, competitive spirit, and wealth of knowledge and it is hardly surprising that his academic career left a lasting mark on the OSU Department of Animal and Food Sciences. In 1991 he was elected as Executive Vice President of the Oklahoma Cattlemen's Association, where he continued to influence the cattle industry until his term ended in 1995. Subsequently, he became president of Express Ranches in Yukon, Oklahoma, where he oversaw one of the largest purebred cattle operations in North America for 27 years and helped innovate and shape the future of the seedstock industry. Callahan was appointed to the Oklahoma A&M Board of Regents in 2016, and he eventually chaired the board from 2022 until his passing. In 2023, he was inducted into the prestigious Saddle and Sirloin Portrait Gallery to recognize his lasting contributions to livestock judging and the beef industry. Callahan's connection to OSU was multifaceted- student, coach, professor, and regent- and his contributions shaped both the university's agricultural programs and the cattle industry nationwide.

Mark Z. Johnson (1992-2013, 2020)

Mark Johnson's passion for livestock and agriculture was fostered on his family's diversified farm and ranch operation in Deerfield, Missouri. This led him to Northeastern Oklahoma A&M College in to earn his Associate's degree in agriculture in 1984 before transferring to Oklahoma State University as a member of the livestock judging team. After a highly successful run with the 1985 Reserve National Champion team coached by Jarold Callahan, Johnson pursued his Master's degree in Ruminant Nutrition from Oklahoma State followed by his Ph.D. in Animal Breeding and Genetics from Kansas State University in 1992. He joined the faculty at Oklahoma State University, where he still serves to this day. His tenure as coach of the livestock judging team reached unprecedented heights for the program. He coached four national champion teams in 2001, 2005, 2010, and 2012, while coaching four reserve national champion teams in 1992,1993,1994 and 2004. His 2005 national champion team still holds the record for the all-time highest score in the history of the contest. His accomplishments earned him recognition with receiving the Coach of the Year Award seven times. From 1992-2013, his teams were either Champion or Reserve Champion team in 70% of the contests in which they competed. He has also managed the OSU Purebred Beef Cattle Center and been a valuable educator in the Department of Animal Science since 1992, specializing in courses involving animal breeding and beef cattle management. Aside from authoring or co-authoring several resources on beef cattle production and management, Johnson's extension efforts include presenting at numerous conferences and meetings throughout the year while being a consistent feature on OSU's SUNUP TV program that educates producers on cost-effective cattle feeding and nutrition strategies. Aside from his university responsibilities, Johnson has served on the American Angus Association Board of Directors since 2024 while continuing to run his family's operation, J&J Cattle Company.

Blake Bloomberg (2014-2019)

Originally from Berwick, Illinois, Bloomberg began his livestock judging career at Black Hawk College before continuing his success at Texas A&M University where he was a member of the national champion team in 2006 that never lost a contest all year. After earning a

Bachelor's degree in animal science and a Master's degree in reproductive physiology from Texas A&M, Bloomberg came to OSU to pursue a Ph.D. in animal science while coaching the livestock judging team. Under his leadership, OSU continued their dominant run with 3 consecutive national champion teams in 2017, 2018, and 2019. He also coached 4 high individuals, with Bloomberg being named Coach of the Year in every year he coached at OSU. He continued adding to his coaching legacy upon joining the faculty of his alma mater, Black Hawk College, in 2020 where he currently coaches and competes at the highest level. Many of his students consider him a life-long mentor who has significantly shaped their professional and personal growth. His impact reaches farther than just his team members and students, as his ownership role in his family's Simmental operation, Bloomberg Cattle Company, and his status as a nationally recognized livestock judge continues to leave its mark on the cattle industry as a whole.

Parker Henley (2021-Present)

Eugene, Missouri, is where Parker Henley grew up raising Charolais and Angus cattle, sparking a lifelong passion for the livestock industry. He began a decorated judging career at Butler Community College before transferring to be on the team at Kansas State University while earning his Bachelor's degree in animal science. The opportunity of pursuing a graduate degree led him to the University of Illinois where he earned his Master's degree and PhD while focusing his research in nutrition and management strategies for heifer and bull development systems. Simultaneously, he began his collegiate coaching career with the university's team. After earning his doctorate, the open coaching position at Oklahoma State University proved to enticing to pass up. Henley is currently the livestock judging team coach and Dr. Robert "Bob" Totusek Endowed Chair Fellow while also serving as an extension specialist focused in beef cattle management and youth livestock selection and education. His short time coaching at the university has brought unprecedented success. Through 5 years, he has coached 4 national champion teams, 1 reserve national champion team, and 2 high individuals at the National Collegiate Livestock Judging Contest. Aside from the numerous other wins and scoring records his teams have broke, Henley is regarded as a dedicated professor who makes a valuable

impact on his students through teaching livestock-based courses in the Animal Science Department.

Building

After introducing livestock evaluation as a course in 1899, it was not long before the university's Animal Husbandry Department decided the team needed a home. The first Livestock Judging Pavilion, a two-story brick structure, was completed by contractor F.A. Brown in 1911. The $15,200 building contained a 50-square-foot arena, classrooms, and an amphitheater. Rapid growth of the department quickly overwhelmed the modest facility, leading to more construction in 1924. The Animal Husbandry Building, which contained a 120- by 60-foot livestock arena, was completed in 1924 at a price of $125,000. The two-story, rounded-roof structure built out of concrete, steel, and brick housed the Department of Animal Husbandry and the Department of Poultry Husbandry. Beginning in 1926, the university's Block and Bridle Club, a national organization for animal husbandry students, began utilizing the livestock arena for annual campus events. The Little International served as a showcase for the college's ever-improving purebred herds. Every October, roughly 1600 students, faculty, and friends of the university would gather in the bleachers of the new Animal Husbandry Building to watch the college's prize cattle be evaluated before they headed to the American Royal and the International livestock shows later in the fall.

The Animal Husbandry Building stood as the headquarters for all things livestock on campus until the 1980s brought a decade of changes for the entire department. Under the leadership of Department Head and former livestock judging coach Dr. Robert Totusek, the Departments of Animal Science, Animal Husbandry, and Animal Nutrition all unified into a singular Department of Animal Science. Simultaneously, the oil boom of the late 1970s and early 1980s led to the state appropriating $15 million to establish a research center for agriculture and renewable natural resources at OSU. Totusek played a pivotal role in establishing the need for new departmental facilities as a part of the center, including the present Animal Science Building and Animal Science Arena. The old Animal Husbandry Building stood in the path of this progress, and was demolished in 1989.

The new 30,000 square foot Animal Science building was completed in 1982 at a cost of $4.5 million. At the time, it was the largest building on campus for a single department and a clear message of both the University's and Department's focus on the future. The Totusek Arena, formerly known as the Animal Science Arena, is a combination livestock and teaching facility that was constructed in 1988 at a price of $3 million. The arena was renamed on April 11, 2015 to honor the late Dr. Robert Totusek, whose 60-year career helped lay the groundwork for what the OSU Animal Science Department is today. Totusek Arena is a state-of-the-art structure with 46,318 square feet. The arena floor measures 92 feet wide by 192 feet long with chairback seating for 779 people. The naming of chairbacks is one of the unique traditions of the Totusek Arena. Judging teams or individuals have the opportunity to purchase a chairback that will display their name or group on an orange plaque. These contributions help support annual scholarships, judging team travel support, and funding for Purebred Center and Teaching Center Endowments.

Other features of the arena include animal holding areas, office and kitchen space, and a 1,675 square foot classroom. It also comes equipped with excellent sound and lighting systems that make it an ideal teaching area and training ground for OSU livestock judging teams, while also appealing to other campus organizations and outside groups. Whether it is departmental events, equestrian meets, or livestock judging contests at all levels, the Totusek Arena holds true to its name and serves to conduct OSU's three-fold land grant mission.

Endowments

The Oklahoma State Livestock Judging Team's Tradition of Excellence could not be possible without the financial support put in place by various alumni and friends of the program. The Totusek Endowed Chair in Animal Science was established in 2005 by former students of the legendary Dr. Tot. Its original goal was set at $500,000, and while this seemed daunting initially, the goal was met in less than year thanks to mostly $100-$250 gifts. These donations would not seem overly significant if looked at individually, but over 400 individuals and industry partners making contributions allowed the goal to be fulfilled so quickly. At the time, this was the greatest number of individual contributors to an endowed chair. Dr. Totusek

is also credited with helping OSU's Animal Science Alumni Association establish five purebred teaching center endowments to support:

- OSU Purebred Beef Center
- OSU Sheep and Goat Center
- OSU Swine Teaching and Research Center
- Charles and Linda Cline Equine Teaching Center
- Ferguson Family dairy

Together, these funds help maintain high-quality purebred herds, teaching laboratories, student learning experiences, and research programs.

Meat Animal Evaluation Team

Introduction

The Meat Animal Evaluation Program was established in 1964 to enhance students' skills in evaluating livestock and carcasses with a primary emphasis on economic value. Students on the team gain a much broader and better understanding of livestock and meat value along with the factors that determine those values, including pricing structures and marketing options. It integrates live animal traits, carcass characteristics, and communication skills to help prepare students for careers in the livestock and meats industries.

Competition

Team members consists of students also participating on either the Oklahoma State livestock judging or meats judging teams. These students participate in training throughout the fall and spring in preparation for their only contest each year and the national championship of the activity, the Meat Animal Evaluation Contest. The MAEC rotates between host institutions across the country and is essentially a three-day marathon, requiring students to stay focused through all four divisions of the contest.

The first division that occurs on the first day of competition is market animal evaluation, in which students estimate fat thickness, rib eye area, Yield Grade, and Quality grade in cattle and sheep. They also estimate fat thickness, loin eye area, and fat free lean percentage in hogs.

The final component of this division is pricing pens of four animals while evaluating performance classes based on an animal's value per day of age. On the second day, students participate in the breeding animal division and evaluate breeding animals with performance data in a contest structured similarly to a normal livestock judging competition. Competitors place classes of livestock, evaluate keep/cull classes, and answer questions at the conclusion of the judging round. The last day includes the meat evaluation division where students place and answer questions on carcasses, price carcasses, and grade carcasses. The last day also provides a communications division, where teams are given a current agriculture issue and are tasked with addressing the topic as a group to a panel of judges. The knowledge and various skills gained from the diverse three-day competition truly makes the MAEC a capstone judging experience for its competitors.

Team Success

Oklahoma State University's Tradition of Excellence extends to the Meat Animal Evaluation Team. Being coached primarily by the current livestock judging coach alongside several animal science faculty members who make valuable contributions, Oklahoma States success is highlighted by the following:

- 3 National Championships
- 3 Reserve National Championships
- 2011 High Individual- Kaylee Kerbs, Saratoga, WY
- 2014 High Individual- Kyle Wilson, Wilkinson, IN
- 2015 High Individual- Blythe Graham, Crossville, TN (All-time record score)
- 2018 High Individual- P.D. Miller, Torrington, WY
- 2019 High Individual- Kash Allen, Keys, OK